



AT THE STATE'S ONLY BIRTHING CENTER, A STRUGGLE TO SURVIVE

By Sarah Rahal
GLOBE STAFF

FLORENCE, Mass. — When Taylor Johnson-Nagy's water finally broke, late on an evening this February, she and her husband didn't head to the hospital 10 minutes away. Instead, they drove two hours from their home in Nashua to a quiet street in Western Massachusetts.

For Johnson-Nagy, the tense journey with her contractions intensifying was a worthy trade-off for the care awaiting her in Florence, home to Seven Sisters Midwifery and Birth Center.

Johnson-Nagy, who is a birth doula, was determined to have her baby outside of a hospital setting.

"I feared intensive medical intervention," she said. "And as a Black woman, I worried about being pushed into a C-section."

Nationally, research shows, Black women are far more likely than white women to have C-sections and, in Massachusetts,

Facilities across New England disappear amid financial challenges



PHOTOS BY ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

Top, Taylor Johnson-Nagy was examined by Ginny Miller at Seven Sisters Midwifery. Above, Johnson-Nagy with her baby, Royal.

twice as likely to die during pregnancy or within one year of giving birth.

Gaps in maternal health care, and the disparities associated with them, have grown wider in the past decade, a period during which 13 hospital maternity units have shut down across Massachusetts. State leaders, including Governor Maura Healey, have pointed to birth centers as a lower-cost, lower-intervention alternative, and have allocated millions of dollars in funding to support them.

But even as policy makers devote cash and attention to birth centers, there's one lingering problem: They've been disappearing. And even Seven Sisters, the last freestanding center in the state, teeters on the brink.

Three birth centers in Massachusetts have closed in recent years, largely due to financial strain. A facility at Holyoke Medical Center shut down in

BIRTH CENTERS, Page A17

Restaurants love a luxury ingredient that protesters say is inhumane

By Celina Colby
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

The battle over luxury dining's most controversial delicacy is intensifying in Boston and throughout the Northeast.

Foie gras, the French dish made with fattened duck or goose liver, has

spurred protests outside Boston restaurants including Pammy's and Asta in recent months, as animal-rights advocates implore chefs to stop serving what they believe is an inhumane ingredient. Last May, Brookline became the first municipality in Massachusetts to prohibit foie gras, enforcing

a penalty of \$300 for each day it's for sale. Meanwhile, a March court ruling means that New York City could soon ban the food, following the example of California, where foie gras has been illegal for several years.

But chefs who serve foie gras say it has deep culinary roots and believe

they deserve the right to choose what they serve. Even as the movement to ban foie gras progresses in parts of the US, the UK government recently reneged on promises to ban foie gras imports in order to facilitate a trade deal with the EU.

FOIE GRAS, Page A16

Construction slowdown puts wrench in city budget

Tax revenue projections are lowest in years

By Catherine Carlock
GLOBE STAFF

As the lack of groundbreakings and cranes has made clear for months, construction has slowed to a crawl in Boston. Now we're learning what that means for the city's bottom line.

In its recently released budget for the coming fiscal year, the Wu administration projects just \$40 million in additional tax revenue from new development, the smallest such sum since 2016.

Persistently high interest rates and construction costs have stalled new development in recent years. In the first quarter, there was just one tower crane active on Boston's skyline, according to construction consulting firm Rider Levett Bucknall, "reflecting fewer new high-rise starts as major projects reach completion."

Meanwhile, many Boston developers have turned to communities outside city limits to build housing, including Revere, Lynn, and Everett.

The slowdown is a warning flag, some say, for a city that relies heavily on property tax revenue to clean streets, fill potholes, and fund schools. And coupled with a nearly \$50 million projected deficit in Boston's \$4.8 billion operating budget, it leaves little room to fund new initiatives, such as fare-free bus lines or the city's energy saver program.

GROWTH, Page A16

Black Market raises money and questions

Nubian Square group encounters challenges

By Janelle Nanos
GLOBE STAFF

A few weeks ago, the owners of Black Market in Nubian Square took to social media with an impassioned plea: Help us save our "sacred space."

In a video, market founders Kai and Chris Grant revealed they were in a dispute with their landlord, the nonprofit Madison Park Development Corp., over the lease of their two-story building, which has served as a small business incubator and community gathering space in Roxbury for nearly a decade. The Grants, who in 2021 had signed a deal to eventually buy the building, were now asking the community for help raising \$369,000 by the end of April to purchase the building. They had just 17 days before that agreement would expire.

"In a time of rapid gentrification and displacement of Black spaces, our fight is not just

BLACK MARKET, Page A13

Tatum-less Celtics deserved to lose

DAN SHAUGHNESSY

Hello darkness.

The sounds of silence will be heard on Causeway Street over the next few months now that the Bruins and Celtics have been eliminated on back-to-back nights at the West End barn.

Exactly when did TD Garden become our Tomb of Doom? Let the record show that starting April 21, the Bruins and Celtics lost six consecutive home playoff games, ending their seasons with a thud on the first weekend in May.

Saturday night it was the Jayson Tatum-less Celtics succumbing to their ancient rival Phila-

delphia 76ers, 109-100, losing in infuriating fashion as a hail of Boston's 3-point shots clanged off Garden rims down the stretch.

Make no mistake: Stubborn Joe Mazzulla and the three-chucking Celtics deserved to lose. Never adjusting, they died by the ridiculous shot, rattling the rim to the tune of 28 percent (36 of 129) from international waters in their final

SHAUGHNESSY, Page C11

The right beard or mustache can add as much to an actor's performance as an accent or gesture, writes Chris Vognar. **SundayArts. N1.**



Yard times

Sunday: Rain early. High: 57-62. Low: 44-49.
Monday: Sunny, breezy. High: 67-72. Low: 50-55. Complete report, **A24.** Deaths, **A18-22.**

New England offers plenty of summer adventures, from the skies of Vermont to the waters of Narragansett Bay. **Globe Magazine.**

The Globe salutes the standout high school athletes of the winter season. **All Scholastics.**

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